

Keeper's Watch

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Reflection

Keeper's Watch

A VR exploration of an abandoned coastal lighthouse — no combat, no objective,
just quiet spatial discovery and a story carried by sound.

SIT253 · Progressive Folio 1 · Experience & Exploration theme · Meta Quest 3S

Photo: Evgeni Tcherkasski / [Unsplash](#)

The Idea

Keeper's Watch places the user inside an abandoned lighthouse and its immediate grounds at dusk — the lamp room, the cliff path, and the rocky shoreline below. There's no combat and no objective. The whole experience is built around quiet spatial discovery, environmental storytelling (what happened to the keeper?), and an atmosphere carried almost entirely by sound: a distant foghorn, waves against rock, wind across the cliff top.

This is the planning stage — working out the theme, researching the genre, building a visual and sonic moodboard, and scoping out exactly what needs to get modelled, recorded, and edited before the lighthouse becomes something you can actually walk around in.

Folio at a Glance

THEME	Experience & Exploration
TARGET PLATFORM	Meta Quest 3S (standalone VR)
TARGET AUDIENCE	Atmospheric/narrative-driven VR explorers, plus maritime heritage groups
PLANNED 3D ASSETS	5 (4 required minimum + 1 stretch) — see Asset Plan
PLANNED AUDIO ASSETS	10 — see Asset Plan

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Folio Inquiry

Photo: Travis Leery / [Unsplash](#)

Theme

Experience & Exploration.

Concept

Keeper's Watch places the user inside an abandoned coastal lighthouse and its immediate grounds at dusk — the lamp room, the cliff path, and the rocky shoreline below. There is no combat or objective; the experience is built entirely around quiet spatial discovery, environmental storytelling (what happened to the keeper?), and atmosphere carried by sound.

Target XR Platform

Meta Quest 3S (standalone, room-scale VR) — the headset I actually own. It runs the same Snapdragon XR2 Gen 2 chipset and 8GB RAM as the Quest 3 (Road to VR, 2024), so the performance headroom I'm designing the models around (see Asset Plan) applies here too. The 3S mainly differs in display resolution (1832×1920 vs 2064×2208) and field of view (96° vs 110°) — that changes how sharp it looks, not what I can actually model.

I picked it because it's untethered and has good hand/controller tracking for close-up interaction with small props — rotating a lobster trap, picking up a lantern. The tight performance budget is also useful pressure: it keeps me optimising instead of just chasing detail.

Target Audience

Adults (16+) interested in atmospheric, narrative-driven exploration experiences — the "walking simulator" VR audience (players of *Firewatch*, *Dear Esther*, *What Remains of Edith Finch*) — plus a secondary audience of local heritage/maritime history groups who could use a piece like this for informal digital-preservation or tourism storytelling.

Ethical Considerations

- **Cultural/historical respect:** the keeper and their story are made up. I didn't want to put words in a real family's mouth just to make the concept sound more grounded.
- **Comfort/accessibility:** VR makes people sick easily, so I'm using teleport locomotion instead of free movement, and the cliff edges get a soft boundary for

anyone with vertigo.

- **Content suitability:** no jump-scares, despite the abandoned setting. This needs to stay a quiet, atmospheric piece, not tip into horror territory.

Why This Concept Fits the Audience

A quiet, abandoned space is a hard thing to sell on a flat screen — it needs presence to land. Standing at the actual scale of the lamp room, hearing the foghorn come from a specific direction outside, noticing how small the space feels compared to the tower's height from outside — that's the kind of thing VR does that video or photos of the same lighthouse can't. For walking-sim VR players, that's the entire appeal of the genre; for heritage groups, it's a way to let people feel a place's atmosphere even after the real site has been automated or fallen into disrepair.

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References

Photo: Igor Peftiev / [Unsplash](#)

Reference List

Almeida, G.C. de, Andrade, A.O. and Vargas, P.A., 2023. Spatial audio in virtual reality: a systematic review. In: *Proceedings of the 22nd Brazilian Symposium on Games and Digital Entertainment*. New York: ACM.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3625008.3625042>

This is what convinced me the sonic moodboard isn't a side task. Spatial audio measurably affects presence, so ambient layering — the direction the foghorn comes from, how the waves sit relative to the wind — is core design work here, not polish added at the end.

Audacity Team, n.d. *Editing audio*. [online] Available at:

support.audacityteam.org/basics/audacity-editing [Accessed 26 Jul. 2026].

Going through the core workflow here — import, trim, layer — before I touch any raw recordings, so I'm not guessing my way through Audacity once Folio 2

production actually starts.

Eggers, R. (dir.), 2019. *The Lighthouse* [Film]. USA: A24.

Referenced for how it lights weathered material — heavy shadow, one hard light source doing all the work. I want the same in the scene: the lamp itself as the dominant light, not even ambient lighting everywhere.

Lamerichs, N., 2016. *The meaning of the island in art game Dear Esther*. [online] Available at: nicollemamerichs.com/2016/03/20/making-sense-of-indie-game-dear-esther [Accessed 26 Jul. 2026].

This is what pushed me toward environmental storytelling instead of a guided tour. The island in *Dear Esther* tells its story through what's been left behind, not dialogue — that's the approach I want for what happened to the keeper.

Lighthouses of Australia, n.d. *Point Lonsdale Lighthouse*. [online] Available at: lighthouses.org.au/vic/point-lonsdale-lighthouse [Accessed 26 Jul. 2026].

Used for real proportions — how tall the tower actually is relative to the lamp room, how big the lamp housing is next to a person — so the Lighthouse Lamp Housing isn't just guessed at.

Meta, n.d. *Testing and performance analysis — Meta Horizon OS Developers*. [online] Available at: developers.meta.com/horizon/documentation/unity/unity-perf [Accessed 26 Jul. 2026].

Source of the 400–600 draw call / 1.3–1.8M triangle numbers on the Asset Plan page. I didn't want to guess at a "reasonable" polycount — I wanted the actual figure Meta recommends for this hardware.

Poeschl, S. and Doering, N., 2013. Integration of spatial sound in immersive virtual environments: an experimental study on effects of spatial sound on presence. In: *2013 IEEE Virtual Reality (VR)*. IEEE, pp.129–130. DOI: 10.1109/VR.2013.6549396. Available at: researchgate.net [IEEE Xplore's own page for this DOI is currently down; ResearchGate mirror used instead].

A second, independent study backing the same conclusion as the Almeida review above. Two separate papers landing on the same point gave me more confidence it's not a one-off finding.

Price, A., n.d. *Blender Guru* [YouTube channel]. Available at: youtube.com/@blenderguru [Accessed 26 Jul. 2026].

The tutorial series I'm actually going to work through on a practice object before touching a real prop — see the Reflection page for why.

Road to VR, 2024. *Quest 3S vs Quest 3 vs Quest 2 compared with detailed specs*.

Hayden, S. [online] Available at: roadtovr.com/quest-3s-quest-3-quest-2-specs-compared [Accessed 26 Jul. 2026].

Confirmed the Quest 3S shares its chipset and RAM with the Quest 3. That's the entire reason I can use Meta's Quest 3 performance figures for a 3S I actually own, instead of guessing at different numbers.

The Chinese Room, 2012. *Dear Esther* [Video game]. UK: The Chinese Room.

The main reference for the whole project, listed separately from Lamerichs' analysis above because I spent time playing it myself, not just reading about it — the pacing of discovery is what I'm trying to replicate.

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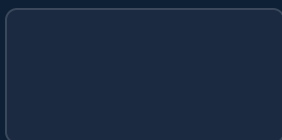
Moodboard

Photo: Reza Madani / [Unsplash](#)

Visual Moodboard

Art style: Stylised low-poly with hand-painted-look textures (flat colour + baked shading, no PBR realism). This is a deliberate choice, not just a beginner shortcut — it fits the Quest 3S triangle budget (see Asset Plan) and matches the painterly, slightly unreal tone of *Dear Esther's* island.

Colour Palette



Deep Navy

#1B2A41



Weathered Teal

#3C6E71



Fog Grey

#D9D9D9



Lamp Amber

#E8A33D



Driftwood Brown

#6B4F3B

I used the same five colours for the site itself, so it actually feels like the place it's describing instead of just writing about it.

Reference Images

Gathered for atmosphere, material, and proportion reference — not for tracing.

Actual props still get modelled from scratch, per the academic integrity requirements on the Folio Inquiry page.



Lamp housing proportions

Reference for the Lighthouse Lamp Housing's scale and glazing pattern. Photo: Katja Ano / [Unsplash](#)



Lighting/atmosphere

The fog density and flat, cool light I'm aiming for in the scene. Photo: Alex Moliski / [Unsplash](#)



Metal weathering

Rust/oxidation pattern for the lamp mechanism and hinges — texture reference, baked in, not modelled. Photo: Volodymyr Leush / [Unsplash](#)



Timber weathering

Grain/greying reference for the
Rowboat, Pier Post, and Lobster
Trap textures. Photo: Sebastian
Schuster / [Unsplash](#)

Still to add: *The Lighthouse* (2019) film stills for lighting reference, and a proper
PureRef board built from these plus more — this is a starting set, not the finished
board.

Sonic Moodboard

One image/audio pair per sound category from the audio asset plan. Four of the
five are locked in and licence-checked; the fifth is still an open pick.

AMBIENT

Fog over dark water

[Foghorn / lighthouse ambience ↗](#)

AMBIENT

Cliffside waves

"Waves and seagulls" by JosephSardin —
[Freesound ↗](#) (CC0, verified)

FOLEY

Seagull on a ledge

"seagull.wav" by speakingmusic — [Freesound ↗](#)
(CC0, verified)

FOLEY

Old timber pier

"Door Creak" by stib — [Freesound ↗](#) (CC0,
verified)

TONAL / MUSICAL

Lamp room interior, warm light

Still open — haven't found a sparse ambient
drone that fits without also pulling in
unrelated nature sounds. Searching

Freesound's "drone" tag further before
locking this in.

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Asset Plan

Photo: paws and prints / [Unsplash](#)

Planned Visual (3D) Assets

Quest 3S caps out around 1.3–1.8M triangles scene-wide (Meta, n.d.; same chipset budget as the Quest 3, per Road to VR, 2024) — that's why nothing below goes past a few thousand tris, even the hero asset.

ASSET NAME	CATEGORY	DESCRIPTION	TARGET POLY COUNT	TEXTURE SIZE
Lighthouse Lamp Housing	Hero prop	The rotating lamp mechanism at the top of the tower — the focal object of the scene.	~4,000 tris	2K (diffuse + emissive for the beam)

Weathered Rowboat	Environment prop	Beached, half-sunk wooden rowboat on the rocks below the cliff.	~1,800 tris	1K
Lobster Trap	Detail prop	Timber-and-rope trap left on the pier, hand interaction target. Simplified from the original plan — rope weave and wood weathering are baked into the texture rather than modelled as geometry, since this is a background prop, not the hero asset.	~900 tris	512×512
Pier Post	Structural prop	Repeating weathered timber post used to dress the pier walkway. Same simplification — weathering/damage detail comes from texture, not modelled variation per post.	~400 tris	512×512
Seagull Nest <i>(stretch, 5th asset)</i>	Detail prop	Small nest on a cliff ledge, adds life/scale to the environment.	~600 tris	512×512

I've planned five props instead of the required four. The Seagull Nest is the one I can cut if time gets tight — more on that call on the Reflection page.

Planned Audio Assets

#	ASSET NAME	CATEGORY	DESCRIPTION	TARGET FORMAT
1	Foghorn_Ambient	Ambient	Distant recurring foghorn, looped	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, stereo
2	Ocean_Waves_Loop	Ambient	Waves against rocks, looped bed layer	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, stereo
3	Wind_Cliffside_Loop	Ambient	Wind gusts across the cliff top	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, stereo

4	Seagull_Call_01/02	Foley	Two seagull call variations, non-looped one-shots	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, mono
5	Pier_Wood_Creak	Foley	Timber creak, triggered near the pier posts	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, mono
6	Lamp_Mechanism_Turn	Foley	Mechanical rotation sound for the lamp interaction	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, mono
7	Footsteps_Gravel	Foley	Player footstep set on the cliff path	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, mono
8	Rope_Creak_Rowboat	Foley	Rope/hull creak near the beached rowboat	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, mono
9	Distant_Bell_Buoy	Ambient/tonal	Faint bell buoy far offshore, ties the scene together sonically	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, stereo
10	Ambient_Drone_LampRoom	Tonal/musical	Sparse ambient drone inside the lamp room	.wav, 44.1kHz/16-bit, stereo

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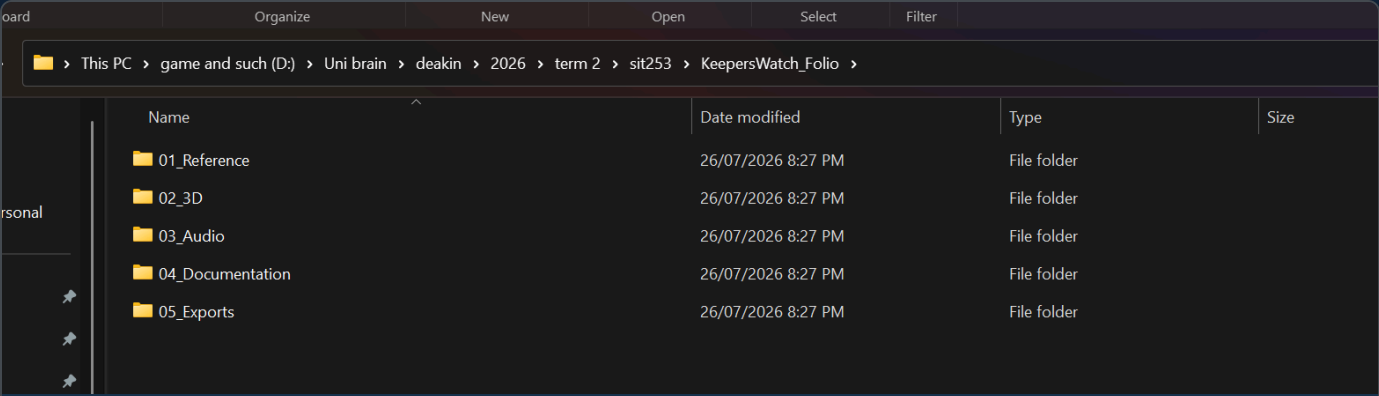
Photo: Fabian S / [Unsplash](#)

Asset Management System

My local folder structure traces straight back to the rows in the Asset Plan tables, so anyone opening it can find an asset without me walking them through it.

```
KeepersWatch_Folio/
├── 01_Reference/           (moodboard exports, research PDFs, citations)
├── 02_3D/
│   ├── LighthouseLamp/    (source .blend, exported .fbx, textures/)
│   ├── Rowboat/
│   ├── LobsterTrap/
│   ├── PierPost/
│   └── SeagullNest/
├── 03_Audio/
│   ├── Raw/               (unedited source recordings/downloads)
│   └── Final/             (edited, folio-ready .wav files)
```

- └─ 04_Documentation/ (asset list .xlsx, timeline .xlsx, working doc)
- └─ 05_Exports/ (final render screenshots, Sketchfab export bundles)



Actual local folder, screenshotted from Explorer — not a mockup.

Naming convention: AssetType_AssetName_Version — e.g.
3D_LighthouseLamp_v2.blend, AUD_Foghorn_Ambient_Final.wav. No generic names ("new folder," "stuff," "test"). Every folder/file name traces directly back to a row in the Asset Plan tables.

Timeline

WEEK	PHASE	PLANNED TASKS & TARGETS	STATUS
Week 3 (now)	Conceptualisation	Lock theme + concept, build visual + sonic moodboard, draft asset list	In progress
Week 4 (Fri 31 Jul)	Progressive Folio 1 due	Submit documentation, references, moodboards, asset plan, asset mgmt, timeline, reflection	Due
Week 5	Technical planning → Execution	Set up Blender project files per folder structure; begin Lighthouse Lamp Housing (hero asset)	Planned
Week 6	Execution	Finish Lighthouse Lamp Housing (textured); begin Rowboat modelling	Planned

Week 7 (Fri 28 Aug)	Progressive Folio 2 due	Minimum 2 completed/textured 3D assets, updated asset mgmt + timeline, reflection	Due
Week 8–9	Execution	Model Lobster Trap + Pier Post; begin recording/sourcing raw audio	Planned
Week 10	Execution	Finish Seagull Nest (stretch asset); edit all 10 audio assets; integrate scene in Sketchfab/engine	Planned
Week 11 (Thu 24 Sep)	Final Folio due	All 4+ models, 10 audio assets, full eFolio polish, freeze + submit PDF	Due

Risk & Plan B

I haven't used Blender before this unit, so the biggest risk is the Lighthouse Lamp Housing (the hero, most complex asset) taking longer than the Week 5–6 window allows while I'm still learning box modelling basics. Plan B is already built into the asset list — the Lobster Trap and Pier Post are scoped to lean on texture detail rather than modelled geometry, so if the Lamp Housing overruns, time can be pulled from those simpler props without cutting an asset entirely.

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Critical Self-Evaluation

Photo: Evgeni Tcherkasski / [Unsplash](#)

1. Shift in Perspective

Three weeks into this unit, the biggest change is that I now think about performance limits from the start instead of treating them as a problem for later. Before this, my instinct with any creative project was to build first and worry about constraints after. Planning *Keeper's Watch* against the Quest 3S's actual triangle and draw-call budget (Meta, n.d.) forced me to design each prop's level of detail before I've modelled anything, which is a different way of working for me.

2. Scoping & Prioritisation

I already simplified the Lobster Trap and Pier Post from my original plan. I'd initially pictured the trap with individually modelled woven rope and the pier posts each showing unique weathering and damage. Realistically, as someone who hasn't done much box modelling yet, that level of per-object detail wasn't a good use of time this early — it's a background/detail prop, not the hero asset. I simplified both to rely more on baked texture detail (rope weave, wood grain, weathering) rather than modelled geometry, which keeps them under budget and achievable without slowing down the Lighthouse Lamp Housing, which is where the real modelling effort should go.

3. Sourcing My Technical Guides

I don't have anything bookmarked yet, so I went looking for reputable channels instead of just grabbing the first search result:

- **Blender Guru** (Andrew Price) — [youtube.com/@blenderguru](https://www.youtube.com/@blenderguru) — widely recommended beginner box-modelling series (his "donut" tutorial is the standard starting point most Blender learners are pointed to).
- **Audacity's own editing documentation** — support.audacityteam.org/basics/audacity-editing — for the core editing workflow (import, trim, layer) before touching looping or noise cleanup on the raw sound files.

4. Identifying Skill Gaps

3D modelling basics is what I'm least confident about — I haven't really used Blender before this unit. My plan is to work through the Blender Guru beginner series on a throwaway practice object (not one of my actual folio props) before Week 5, so I've made my early mistakes somewhere that doesn't cost me time on the Lighthouse Lamp Housing itself. If box modelling turns out to take longer

than expected, that's exactly why the Lobster Trap and Pier Post are already scoped down — that's my Plan B built in from the start.

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